

SIGNIFICANCE—THE MIRROR IMAGE

My father is a great man who influenced many people, great and small, from national business leaders to students to students of his students who went into other fields. He had a knack for getting people to see things they wouldn't see otherwise, not by telling them but by some-how getting them to think thoughts they don't believe they ever would have thought without interaction with him. At times, it was like he was a mirror held up to your brain.

I can't tell you how many people over the decades said something to me like, "I met him once. It was only briefly, but he said x, y, and z, and that made me think, and that gave me the idea I used in starting my company." It was, of course, their idea, but they somehow credited him with some of its creation. He brought that quality out in people. Somehow he made people think things that they might have thought anyway, but for sure they believed they thought them because of interactions with Father. I remember some of these people clearly, and to my certain knowledge Father didn't say the things that some people thought he said. But somehow they heard the right words anyway, and that is all that counts for them. His writings are like that, too, and always have been for many people. Many investors have told me over the decades how they did this or that because of something they read in *Common Stocks and Uncommon Profits* or in *Conservative Investors Sleep Well*. Of course, they didn't. They did whatever they did because of something in them, in their mind. But they believe it was inspired by something they read in those books. The books are good. The inspirations are even better.

And that is a very good thing. If you read my father's writings and ideas come to you, ones he never really said, and if you are motivated by them, so much the better. It is another reason that re-reading his books is useful. Somehow, my father was a mirror for many people: He let them see themselves in ways they believe they wouldn't have otherwise. Now, forty-five years after *Common Stocks and Uncommon Profits* first appeared, my father will never directly have that impact on anyone again. But his writings carry on. If you've never read him, I hope you enjoy this man. If you've read him before, I welcome you back. With the response his writings have